

As Argentina prepares to defend its World Cup crown, Lionel Messi reflects on the triumph in Qatar, his bond with coach Lionel Scaloni, and the challenges awaiting the reigning champions at the 2026 FIFA World Cup.

How important was the night of December 18, 2022, in Qatar?

One of the most special nights for all of us Argentinians, and a very, very special night for the group and for me as well. We tried everything in every edition to win the World Cup again after 1986, but we returned empty-handed. On that night at the Lusail Stadium, the dream came true

have to be prepared to face tough times.

Winning the World Cup for Argentina has always highlighted a special bond between the coach and the captain. Luis César Menotti had Daniel Passarella, while Carlos Bilardo's go-to man was Diego Maradona. Do you have the same bond with Lionel Scaloni?

Well, we were teammates at the 2006 World Cup, where Scaloni was senior to me, and I was almost a kid. He was a great teammate because he always had something hilarious to say, and we all used to laugh. He has changed a lot as the manager of the side, but

genius too. We do share great trust.

Can Argentina retain the title?

Nobody can say for sure! It's the World Cup, the greatest football tournament, and every team will try its best to win it. Yes, we are preparing with the same intensity and shall give our all to do our best. We have a strong group of exceptional players who are hungry for more success. They are champions, but they want more. It creates a wonderful atmosphere in the dressing room and, for that, once again, Scaloni and his group deserve kudos.

Which teams are capable of spoiling the party for Argentina at

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for all of us. We had to wait a long 36 years for it. That made it even more special!

Under your leadership, Argentina will be playing another World Cup in the United States, Canada and Mexico in a few days. For the first time, you will enter the competition as the defending champion. Added pressure?

Playing for Argentina is always an honour for me. I have always said so and enjoyed every bit of it. Yes, there were times when we didn't perform well and couldn't satisfy our fans. But we always gave our best on the field. The last few years have been exceptional, as we have won three major tournaments: two Copa América titles and the World Cup. It really felt great to achieve something for the nation. We shall be trying to do the same again. However, things will be different this time because our opponents will treat us as the defending champions, and we shall

his way of working is still the same. He talks directly to all the players in the squad and makes them understand what he is looking for. That's simply great. He knows what to do before and during a match; his vision is clear. And like everyone else in the squad, I too feel the same warmth when we talk.

You had a special relationship with Pep Guardiola at Barcelona, too.

Pep is a genius as a coach. See what he has done. Not only did his teams play differently, but he also changed the way football is played in Germany and England. That's huge! Scaloni has been brilliant in his own way in making us believe in ourselves. He has built this team. Argentine footballers know that wherever they play, Scaloni will be watching them. If a player is good enough, he will definitely be called up.

This is an added motivation. His communication skills are extraordinary. Definitely, he is a

the forthcoming World Cup?

France is obviously there, as they have been in the last two editions. They reached both finals, winning one. Then there is Spain, a team full of extraordinarily talented footballers. Brazil has been waiting to be crowned champions for many years now. They will be eager. So will Germany and England.

The Argentine fans will definitely be behind you and the team and expect another success...

That is quite natural. I know it very well. If you remember, after we lost the first match in Qatar, against Saudi Arabia, I repeatedly told the fans to back us because I knew the group very well and believed in their abilities. They stood behind us, and we were successful in our effort to win the Cup. They will expect us to do the same again, but it's never easy. For me, the future is more important than the past. We promise to give our best, as always. The rest remains to be seen.